

Copter CABINET

Orissa ministers shun terra firma and take to the skies to clock frequent flyer miles on public money

By **Farzand Ahmed**
in Bhubaneswar

Why walk when you can drive? And why drive when you can fly? Nowhere is this truer than in Orissa, where Chief Minister Naveen Patnaik's cabinet colleagues seem to be coptering their way to new heights of profligacy. Take Khurda, barely 30 km from the state capital Bhubaneswar. It's a distance even an outdated Ambassador car would cover in 45 minutes, and a return journey would need less than 10 litres of petrol. But the times are changing, and dearly so. Some of Patnaik's colleagues prefer to hire helicopters for a trip such as this at a cost of Rs 60,000 per hour.

Konark is only 65 km from the capital and by road it takes about 90 minutes. But that didn't stop a minister from chartering a helicopter at a cost of Rs 1.20 lakh for the two-hour trip. Chartered helicopters cost about Rs

THE CHIEF MINISTER HAS MADE 63 TRIPS IN THREE YEARS AT A COST OF RS 38 LAKH

50,000 an hour to use; the waiting charge is Rs 10,000 per hour. But it's all official, and so what if the places helicopters are taken to are a few hours away from Bhubaneswar by road: Bhadrak, Sukinda, Kanshi, Jaleswar, Balasore and Malud, all on highways considered good by Orissa standards. These are only a few examples of Orissa's high-flying ministers, and in a state that official

statistics say is among the poorest, where 57 per cent of the population lives on Rs 12 or less a day.

According to the details given by the government's General Administration (GA) Department, the Orissa Government spends at least Rs 1 crore every year on helicopters chartered for the chief minister, ministers and select bureaucrats. Between 2005-06 and 2007-08, Patnaik and his minis-



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